

YUFEI ZHANG

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Last updated: August 20, 2026

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Mental health and social inequality across the life course; aging and social representations; computational social science.

EDUCATION

Nanjing University M.A. in Journalism and Communication (Computational Communication) GPA: 4.00/4.00	Nanjing, China 2024–2027
Communication University of China B.Eng. in Cyberspace Security; Minor in Computational Communication GPA: 3.64/4.00	Beijing, China 2020–2024

PEER-REVIEWED ARTICLES AND REGISTERED REPORTS

- [1] **Zhang, Y.**, & Ma, Z. (2025). Depression trajectories from mid to late life (50–89 years): The roles of cohort, multimorbidity status, and national contexts across nine European countries. *Social Science & Medicine*, 385, 118605. doi:10.1016/j.socscimed.2025.118605
- [2] **Zhang, Y.**, & Ma, Z. (2026). Depressive symptom trajectories around the retirement transition across countries and historical periods [Stage 2 Registered Report]. *PsyArXiv*. doi:10.31234/osf.io/6ypwr_v6 Peer-reviewed and recommended by Peer Community in Registered Reports (PCI RR).

PREPRINTS AND MANUSCRIPTS

- [1] **Zhang, Y.**, & Ma, Z. (2026). Psychometric comparability of LLM-based digital twins. *SSRN*. doi:10.2139/ssrn.5967255 Revise and resubmit at Nature Communications.
- [2] **Zhang, Y.**, & Ma, Z. (2026). Loneliness from midlife to older adulthood reflects both stable trait and changing circumstance. *PsyArXiv*. doi:10.31234/osf.io/7fc9v_v1 Under review.
- [3] **Zhang, Y.**, & Ma, Z. (2026). Digital exclusion among middle-aged and older adults in China: Age–period–cohort evidence from three national surveys, 2011–2022. *PsyArXiv*. doi:10.31234/osf.io/hpv68_v1 Under review.
- [4] Yang, Y., **Zhang, Y.**, & Ma, Z. (2026). Quality of life in middle and later life across Europe: Trait–occasion decomposition using the measurement-aligned SHARE CASP-12. *PsyArXiv*. doi:10.31234/osf.io/hwaks_v1 Under review. Contributions: Data curation, formal analysis, and methodology.
- [5] Yang, Y., **Zhang, Y.**, & Ma, Z. (2026). Early identification of adolescent mental health risk through integrated game-based assessment and large language model psychological inference. Under review at *The British Journal of Social Work*. Contributions: Data curation, formal analysis, and methodology.

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

- [1] **Zhang, Y.**, & Ma, Z. (2025, November). Psychometric evaluation of zero-shot LLM-based digital twins from self-report data: Agreement, bias, and calibration. *2025 Annual Conference of the Jiangsu Psychological Society*. Oral presentation.
- [2] Yang, Y., **Zhang, Y.**, & Ma, Z. (2026, July). Early identification of adolescent mental health risk through integrated game-based assessment and LLM psychological inference. *Second International Workshop on Human–Machine Communication, Psychology, and Social Change*, Shenzhen University, Shenzhen, China. Second Prize.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Computational Communication Collaboratory, Nanjing University Graduate Researcher Supervisor: Zhihao Ma	Nanjing, China 2024–Present
Psychological Adaptation and Social Participation from Midlife to Later Life • Lead the design and analysis of longitudinal and cross-national studies examining how age, cohort, retirement transitions, and national contexts shape depression, loneliness, and social participation from midlife to later life. Apply age–period–cohort, multilevel, latent-variable, and longitudinal models to investigate digital exclusion and socioeconomic and health inequalities across midlife and later life.	Sep. 2024–Present
Digital Twin Psychometrics • Evaluate the psychometric comparability of LLM-based digital twins and human respondents across psychological, behavioral, and open-ended text tasks. • Design multi-study evaluations across models and prompting conditions to assess construct validity and human–LLM alignment using psychometric, network, calibration, and text-analytic methods.	Aug. 2025–Present

- Constructing Old Age: A Cross-National Diachronic Analysis of Aging Narratives

Oct. 2025–Present
- Analyze cross-national and historical changes in narratives of aging using large-scale diachronic corpora and word embeddings.
 - Examine age stereotypes and social representations through semantic association and multilevel analyses.

RESEARCH METHODS

Statistical & Psychometric Methods: Longitudinal modeling; multilevel modeling; age–period–cohort analysis; latent-variable modeling; measurement comparability.

Computational Methods: Transformer-based NLP; distributional semantics (word embeddings).

TEACHING AND PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Teaching Assistant, Nanjing University	
Computational Communication Research Training Program (Graduate Course)	Fall 2026
Causal Inference (Graduate Course)	Spring 2026
Applications of LLMs in Digital Humanities (Undergraduate Course)	Spring 2026
Social Research Methods (Undergraduate Course)	Fall 2025, Fall 2026
Academic Writing and Social Research Methods (Undergraduate Course)	Spring 2025
Reporting Intern, Hong Kong, Macao, and Taiwan Desk, Xinhua News Agency	May–Aug. 2023

RESEARCH GRANT

Determinants of Digital Exclusion Among Middle-Aged and Older Adults	Nov. 2025
Distinguished Talent Cultivation Program (2025GYB18) Principal Investigator RMB 6,000	

SELECTED HONORS AND AWARDS

Excellent Graduate Student, Nanjing University	Dec. 2025
National Scholarship for Graduate Students	Nov. 2025
First-Class Academic Scholarship	Nov. 2025
Second-Class Academic Scholarship	Dec. 2024